

Oscar Larnce



"Somewhere the sun is shining, somewhere hearts are light..."
Baseball opens today just as it has for 100 years in spite of a long winter of discontent which threatened the annual rites of spring. The controversy goes on but will be forgotten with Gary Nolan's first pitch to the Houston Astros before a capacity crowd at Cincinnati's Riverfront Stadium. Cincy folks have been celebrating since their Reds beat Boston in the great World Series last October. The Reds are odds on favorites to take everything as the National League begins its second century. Houston is rebuilding and will be lucky to get out of the cellar.

The New York Yankees, their big bats long gone, open in Milwaukee picked to finish third in the American League East behind Boston and Baltimore. All other teams wait until Friday with the Texas Rangers starting a nine-game home stand against the Minnesota Twins, followed by Oakland and Milwaukee. Pitching depth is again the Rangers' big problem. Bill Singer and Nelson Briles may or may not be over arm troubles. Only veteran Gaylord Perry and youngster Jim Umberger are proven quantities. Texas is third choice in the West with perennial winner Oakland and Kansas City rated one-two.

Everybody picks Philadelphia will replace Pittsburgh in the National East but we like the Pirates best with Philadelphia second followed by St. Louis, New York, Montreal and Chicago. Los Angeles looks best for second place in the West despite departure of Andy Messersmith, who's finding trouble on the bidding market and may not play.

Baltimore 'Robbed' Finley

San Francisco could challenge the Dodgers but not the Reds. San Diego, Atlanta and Houston should finish in that order. Maybe Kansas City should be the American West favorite since Baltimore "stole" superstar Reggie Jackson and 20-game winner Ken Holtzman from Charlie Finley. California could move up if Nolan Ryan's strikeout arm has recovered. Milwaukee and Detroit will fight for fifth and sixth.

There may be lots of changes before the season has gone far. Several top players are not signed and playing out their options. They may or may not get their asking price. It's a season of trial for two rookie managers from the minors. Karl Kuehl of Montreal and Joe Frazier of the New York Mets. Both may turn into successes like Walt Alston, Sparky Anderson and Earl Weaver, all of whom proved big winners after sojourns in the bushes. For some, it is a year of decision. Brooks Robinson, Baltimore's Mr. Third Base, says he'll quit if he doesn't hit much better than last year.

Andy Cohen, Waco Cub of 50 years ago, had a perfect record as major league manager. In 1960, Eddie Sawyer came back to Philadelphia, where he'd won the National League pennant 10 years before. He returned to retirement when Robin Roberts lost the opening game in Cincinnati. Cohen, a Philly coach, was given the job until Gene Mauch could be called up from Minneapolis. Andy won his only game before the home crowd in 10 innings. Mauch took over the next day.

Alvin Dark, Philly shortstop, stroked the 2,000th hit of his career. Curt Simmons started but needed help from Ruben Gomez and Don Cardwell.

Feller Hurlled No-Hitter

Washington Hall of Fame pitcher Walter Johnson started 14 opening games and won nine, the last at 38, when he beat Eddie Rummel of the Philadelphia Athletics. Rummel later was an American League umpire for many years. Bob Feller of Cleveland pitched the only opening day no-hitter against the Chicago White Sox in 1940. Chuck Tanner, pinch-hitting for the Milwaukee Braves in 1955, hit the first pitch for a home run, a first-game record which may be tied but never broken. Babe Ruth always was great on opening days with an average of over .400.

Opening day once was a much bigger occasion. There were parades, celebrations, stores closed in some places, and free tickets were given for identifying players from newspaper pictures. Often there were free refreshments.

This week 50 years ago, Morley Jennings, an old major-league player, succeeded Frank Bridges as Baylor football coach. Bridges resigned in a dispute over an athletic department financial statement. Waco boy Bennie Lee Boynton, All-America at Williams College, was favorite for the job but withdrew. Other candidates were Texas freshman coach Clyde Littlefield, Baylor greats Wesley Bradshaw and Tweet Fouts, Austin College coach Pete Cawthon, Howard Payne coach Dad Amis and Vanderbilt coach Josh Cody. Jennings was chosen on recommendation of Texas Aggie coach Dana Bible. He had coached 14 years at Ouachita College in Arkansas, had 10 football and 10 baseball championships, and undefeated football seasons in 1924 and 1925. Jennings stayed through the 1940 season. He had 34-45-5 Southwest Conference and 83-60-6 overall records. He was athletic director at Texas Tech several years and still lives in Lubbock.

One-time quarterback Joe Kapp got exactly what he deserved in his million dollar suit against pro football—nothing.